2026-27 EDITION

The Indian Driving Licence & RTO Playbook

Get your licence. Renew it. Handle every RTO paperwork — with the new 2026 rules decoded.

- Learner's licence to permanent DL, step by step
- The new Hazard Perception Test and what it asks
- Road signs and a sample learner's test
- Complete fee sheet and document checklists
- PUC, FASTag, RC transfer, NOC and challans
- Licence validity, renewal and digital DL/RC

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How to use this guide

This playbook is written for the person at the counter: the 18-year-old booking a first learner's licence, the 40-year-old whose licence is up for renewal, and the family that just bought a used car and needs the RC transferred. Every rule, fee and date here is drawn from official sources — the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), the Parivahan/SARATHI and VAHAN portals, state transport departments, and the Motor Vehicles Act and Central Motor Vehicles Rules. Where a figure can differ from state to state, the guide says so and tells you where to confirm it.

Read Part 1 to understand what changed in 2026, then jump to the part you need. The fee sheet (Part 9), the document checklist (Part 10) and the challan table (Part 18) are designed to be kept open on your phone at the RTO. The 30-day action plan (Part 19) turns the whole thing into a checklist you can follow.

A word on accuracy

Transport is a shared subject: the Centre sets the law and the maximum fees, and each state runs its own RTO software, fees and timelines. This guide gives the national position and flags the state-level variation. Before you pay or travel, confirm the exact amount and slot on your state's SARATHI page — the steps below tell you how.

Part 1. The 2026 licence landscape: what actually changed

Four quiet but real shifts have reshaped how you get and hold a licence in India in 2026. Knowing them saves you a wasted trip and, often, a wasted fee.

1.1 The learner's licence went online and faceless

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways now offers a learner's licence service that needs no RTO visit at all. You fill the form, pay the fee, and take an AI-proctored online test using Aadhaar-based authentication and face recognition. Clear it and the learner's licence can be downloaded instantly. Not every state has switched on the fully faceless version — some still ask you to visit the RTO with your originals — but the online route is the same portal either way.

1.2 The driving test is gaining a cognitive stage

From 1 December 2026, Kerala becomes the first state in India to add a mandatory computer-based Hazard Perception Test (HPT) to the driving test. Instead of only proving you can control a vehicle, you must show you can spot a developing danger — a child stepping out, a car pulling from a side lane — and react in time. Telangana has also proposed a mandatory online road-safety awareness test before the learner's stage. The direction is clear: licences are getting a safety-thinking component, and other states are likely to follow Kerala's model.

1.3 Digital documents are becoming the default

Tamil Nadu moved its driving licences and registration certificates to digital issuance from 15 September 2026, downloadable through SARATHI, VAHAN, DigiLocker and mParivahan. Nationally, a licence or RC pulled up in DigiLocker or mParivahan is treated as valid proof when an officer asks. The physical card is still issued, but the digital copy is what you will reach for at most checkpoints.

1.4 Enforcement is now automated

AI traffic cameras, automatic number-plate recognition and integrated transport databases now issue many challans without an officer stopping you. Unpaid dues are increasingly linked to RTO services. And since January 2026, five or more traffic offences in a year can cost you a three-month licence suspension — including for offences as ordinary as a loose helmet strap or a skipped seat belt.

Why this matters for your money

The same 2026 rules that make the licence easier to apply for make non-compliance more expensive. A missing PUC can now attract a penalty of up to Rs. 10,000 plus a three-month disqualification; driving without a licence is Rs. 5,000. Staying current on the paperwork is now the cheap option.

Part 2. Pick the right licence class — and the age you qualify

Your licence is issued for specific classes of vehicle. Applying for the wrong class is one of the most common reasons an application is returned. Here is the full menu, in the words the form uses.

2.1 The classes on Form 2

Class (as printed)	What it lets you drive
MCWOG	Motor Cycle Without Gear — a gearless two-wheeler (a scooter or moped).
MCWG	Motor Cycle With Gear — a geared motorcycle.
LMV	Light Motor Vehicle — a car, jeep or van (unladen weight up to 7,500 kg).
LMV-NT	Light Motor Vehicle, Non-Transport — the private-car version.
Transport (Medium / Heavy)	Goods or passenger vehicles run commercially — needs a transport licence.
Adapted Vehicle	A vehicle modified for use by a person with a disability (Divyangjan).
E-Rickshaw / E-Cart	Electric rickshaws and carts.
Others	Harvester, excavator, fork lift, crane-mounted vehicle, tractor, tow truck and similar.

2.2 The age rules

Minimum age	What you can apply for
16 years	MCWOG (a gearless two-wheeler) as a private vehicle.
18 years	LMV and MCWG (a car or a geared motorcycle) as a private vehicle; also a conductor's licence.
20 years	A transport vehicle licence (commercial goods or passenger vehicle).

A 16- or 17-year-old applicant needs a parent's or guardian's declaration with the application. Once you are 18, you can hold an LMV and an MCWG together, and you can add a class to an existing licence at any time later.

2.3 Non-transport versus transport

A non-transport licence is for your own vehicle. A transport licence is for earning — driving a taxi, a truck, a bus, or any vehicle that carries goods or passengers for hire. Transport licences have a shorter validity, need a medical certificate in Form 1A, and require a pass in the eighth standard. If you plan to drive for a living, start with the transport class; you cannot switch a private licence into a commercial one without a fresh test.

Part 3. The learner's licence, step by step

The learner's licence is a six-month permission to practise on the road with an 'L' board. It is the first gate. Here is the whole sequence.

3.1 Before you start: what you need ready

- **Proof of age and address** — Aadhaar is the simplest single document that serves as both. Alternatives include passport, voter ID (electoral roll), school certificate, birth certificate, or a government pay slip.
- **Form 1** — a self-declaration of physical fitness (for non-transport licences).
- **Form 1A** — a medical certificate from a registered medical practitioner, needed for transport licences and for anyone above 40 renewing a licence.
- **A recent passport photograph and your signature**, scanned to the size the portal asks for.
- **Aadhaar-linked mobile number** — for OTP and, in the faceless route, for the online test.

3.2 The online application

1. Go to the SARATHI portal (sarathi.parivahan.gov.in) and select your state.
2. Choose 'Application for New Learner's Licence' from the Learner's Licence menu.
3. Fill Form 2 with your personal details, class of vehicle, and address; upload the documents, photo and signature.
4. Pay the fee online (learner's licence Rs. 150 per class plus a test fee of Rs. 50).
5. Book a slot for the learner's test — or, in the fully online states, take the AI-proctored test then and there.

3.3 The learner's test

The test checks that you recognise road signs, basic rules and safe behaviour. In the online format it is proctored through your camera with Aadhaar-based face authentication. In the RTO format it is a screen test at the counter, often with a set number of questions and a fixed pass mark. Clear it and your learner's licence is generated — download Form 3 from SARATHI or collect it from the office. Part 5 shows the signs and rules the test draws on.

The 30-day rule you must not miss

You cannot take the permanent driving test on the day you get the learner's licence. A mandatory gap applies — traditionally 30 days — between passing the learner's test and appearing for the driving test. In Kerala's new four-stage process, the Hazard Perception Test must also be cleared within 30 days of the learner's test.

3.4 Practising on a learner's licence

- Display an 'L' board at the front and rear of the vehicle while you practise.
- Carry your learner's licence at all times.
- On a two-wheeler, you may not carry a pillion passenger other than an instructor.
- A learner's licence is valid for six months from issue. If it lapses before you take the driving test, you must apply again.

Part 4. The permanent driving licence

The permanent licence is the one you keep. The test has a ground part and a road part — and, from December 2026 in Kerala, a new cognitive stage before both.

4.1 Book the driving-test slot

1. Log in to SARATHI and select your state, then 'Driving Licence' → slot booking for the driving test.
2. Enter your application or learner's licence number and date of birth, and pick an available date and time at your RTO.
3. Note the mandatory gap: the slot must fall after the required waiting period from your learner's test.
4. Carry originals on the day — learner's licence, Form 1, fee receipt, appointment slip and a passport photo.

4.2 The ground test

The ground test (Part I) checks control: starting and stopping smoothly, reversing, an 'H' or '8' figure for two-wheelers, and handling the vehicle in a confined space. For a car, expect the reverse-parallel manoeuvre and a controlled stop. Turn up in a vehicle that matches your licence class, with valid papers.

4.3 The road test

The road test (Part II) is your driving observed on a public road. The examiner watches mirror use, lane discipline, signalling, speed control, overtaking judgement and how you handle junctions and pedestrians. Smooth, predictable driving beats fast driving every time.

4.4 The new Hazard Perception Test

From 1 December 2026, Kerala inserts a computer-based Hazard Perception Test between the learner's test and the practical tests. It is the first such test in India, modelled on the UK and Australian systems. Here is exactly how it works:

Element	Detail
Format	10 video clips, each about one minute long.
Hazards	Each clip features a maximum of two developing hazards.
Scoring	10 marks per clip, 100 in total; full marks for a timely response, deductions for a late one.
Pass mark	60 out of 100 (60 per cent).
Timing	Must be cleared within 30 days of passing the learner's test.
Sequence	Learner's test → Hazard Perception Test → ground test → road test.

The test rewards anticipation, not speed of driving. Watch the whole clip, not just the centre of the road: hazards come from the edges — a parked car whose door may open, a pedestrian at the kerb, a cyclist wobbling ahead. Training is now part of authorised driving schools in Kerala, using open-source hazard-perception tools.

If you are not in Kerala

Only Kerala has notified the Hazard Perception Test so far. But the Central Motor Vehicles Rules already allow such an assessment, and Telangana has proposed a road-safety awareness test. Treat the HPT as a preview of where licensing is going and check your own state's transport department site for updates.

4.5 Ten things that fail candidates

- Arriving in the wrong class of vehicle, or a vehicle without valid papers.
- Forgetting the 'L' board on the practice vehicle.
- Not carrying the learner's licence or the appointment slip.
- Poor mirror discipline — checking mirrors once instead of throughout the drive.
- Rolling back on a slope or stalling repeatedly.
- Not signalling, or signalling after the manoeuvre.
- Driving too fast for the road, or too timidly to keep with traffic.
- Ignoring a zebra crossing or a pedestrian waiting to cross.
- Failing to observe the examiner's instructions clearly.
- Booking a slot before the mandatory waiting period has passed.

Part 5. Road signs and a sample learner's test

The learner's test is largely a sign-recognition and rules test. Indian road signs come in three families, and knowing which family a sign belongs to tells you what it means even when you have not seen that exact sign before.

5.1 The three families of signs

Family	Shape and colour	What it tells you
Mandatory	Red circle (or an octagon / inverted triangle)	A rule you must follow — stop, give way, no entry, a speed limit.
Cautionary	Red triangle with a white centre	A warning — a hazard or a change in the road ahead.
Informatory	Blue rectangle or square	Information — a facility, a direction or guidance.

5.2 Mandatory signs (red circle)

Sign	Meaning
Stop	Come to a complete stop, then proceed only when clear.
Give Way	Slow down and let traffic on the main road pass.
No Entry	Do not enter this road.
One Way	Traffic flows in one direction only.
Speed Limit	The maximum speed allowed, in km/h.
No Overtaking	Do not overtake in this stretch.
No Parking / No Stopping	You may not park, or stop, as indicated.
Compulsory Turn Left / Right	You must turn in the direction shown.
Horn Prohibited	Do not sound the horn — common near schools and hospitals.
No U-Turn	A U-turn is not allowed here.

5.3 Cautionary signs (red triangle)

Sign	Meaning
Right / Left Hand Curve	The road bends ahead.
Narrow Road / Narrow Bridge	The carriageway narrows; slow down.
Cross Road / Side Road	A junction is coming up.
Roundabout	A rotary intersection ahead.
Steep Ascent / Steep Descent	A sharp climb or fall in the road.
Speed Breaker / Hump	A raised hump across the road.
Pedestrian Crossing	A zebra crossing ahead.
School Ahead	Children may be crossing; drive slowly.
Men at Work	Road work in progress.
Slippery Road	The surface may be slippery, especially when wet.

5.4 Informatory signs (blue)

Sign	Meaning
Parking / No Parking zone	Where you may or may not park.
Bus Stop	A designated bus stop.
Hospital / First Aid	A hospital or first-aid post nearby.
Petrol Pump	Fuel station ahead.
Eating Place / Resting Place	A facility on the route.
Toilet	Public convenience.
No Through Road	The road is a dead end.
U-Turn	A U-turn is permitted ahead.

5.5 Twenty practice questions

These are the kind of questions a learner's test asks. Try them before you look at the answers.

Question	Answer
Q1. What does a red traffic light mean?	Stop completely behind the stop line and wait.
Q2. What does a flashing amber (yellow) light mean?	Slow down and proceed with caution.
Q3. At a zebra crossing with a pedestrian waiting, who has the right of way?	The pedestrian — stop and let them cross.
Q4. On which side do you overtake another vehicle?	The right.
Q5. At a roundabout, whom must you give way to?	Traffic already on the roundabout, approaching from your right.
Q6. What must you carry while driving?	A valid licence, RC, insurance and PUC certificate.

Question	Answer
Q7. What does a 'Horn Prohibited' sign mean?	You must not sound the horn in that zone.
Q8. What is the minimum age for an MCWG (geared motorcycle) licence?	18 years.
Q9. What should you do at a yellow box junction?	Do not enter unless your exit is clear.
Q10. What does a flashing red signal at a railway crossing mean?	Stop; proceed only when the way is clear and the gate is open.
Q11. What is the safe distance to keep from the vehicle ahead?	Enough to stop safely if it brakes suddenly — at least a two-second gap.
Q12. Before changing lanes, what should you do?	Check mirrors, signal, check the blind spot, then move.
Q13. How long is a learner's licence valid?	Six months from the date of issue.
Q14. What is the minimum age for a transport vehicle licence?	20 years.
Q15. What does a continuous white line down the middle of the road mean?	Do not cross or overtake across it.
Q16. When must you use your indicator?	Before turning, changing lanes or pulling out — early enough to warn others.
Q17. What should you do at a 'Give Way' sign?	Slow down and let traffic on the main road pass before you proceed.
Q18. Whose responsibility is it to ensure all passengers wear seat belts?	The driver's.
Q19. What is the fine for riding without a helmet?	Rs. 1,000, plus a three-month licence disqualification.
Q20. Can you use a hand-held phone while driving?	No — it attracts a fine of Rs. 5,000 (first offence).

The exact number of questions and the pass mark vary by state and by test format. The purpose is the same everywhere: confirm you can read the road before you are let loose on it.

Part 6. Choosing a driving school (and what it should cost)

You are not required to attend a driving school — but most first-time candidates do, and the difference between a good school and a bad one is measured in test attempts.

6.1 What a good school gives you

- **Real behind-the-wheel hours**, not just classroom time. Ask how many hours of actual driving you get before the test.
- **The test vehicle** — ideally the school provides a vehicle of your licence class, with valid papers, for the test itself.
- **Slot help** — the school should know the local RTO's slot system and timelines.
- **Hazard-perception training** in Kerala, where schools are required to train candidates on the new test using open-source tools.

- **A written fee structure** with no hidden 'agent' charges.

6.2 What to check before you pay

Check	Why it matters
Is the school authorised / recognised?	Only authorised schools are counted for the rules that require training.
How many hours of driving?	Two or three hours is not enough; ask for a realistic figure.
Is the test vehicle included?	Some schools charge extra on test day.
Total fee, in writing	Car courses in metros commonly run from about Rs. 6,000 to Rs. 15,000.
Refund and re-test policy	Know what happens if you fail the first attempt.

The one thing to refuse

No school or agent can legally get you a licence without you passing the tests. Anyone promising a licence 'without test' or 'fixed' is describing a scam, and a licence obtained that way can be cancelled — leaving you with nothing. Walk away.

Part 7. The transport (commercial) licence pathway

If you plan to drive for a living, the route is longer and the licence is different. Here is the pathway for a taxi, truck, bus or school-van licence.

7.1 Who needs a transport licence

You need one to drive any vehicle that carries goods or passengers for hire: a taxi or cab, an auto-rickshaw run commercially, a goods truck, a bus, or a school van. A private car licence does not cover any of these.

7.2 Eligibility

- **Age** — 20 years.
- **Education** — a pass in the eighth standard (the requirement does not apply to a renewal or to adding a transport class to a licence already held).
- **Medical** — a medical certificate in Form 1A, valid for one year.
- **Training** — a driving-school certificate in Form 5 for the relevant class, where the state requires it.

7.3 The steps

1. Get a learner's licence for the transport class (apply as in Part 3, with Form 1A).
2. Complete the required training at an authorised driving school.
3. Book and pass the driving test with a vehicle of the transport class.
4. Add the Public Service Vehicle (PSV) badge if you will carry passengers commercially.
5. For heavy transport vehicles, some states require a one-day refresher course at an approved driving school before renewal.

7.4 Validity

A transport licence is valid for five years from issue or renewal; a licence to carry dangerous or hazardous goods is valid for three years. The PSV badge validity follows state policy. Because the validity is short, put the renewal date in your calendar the day you receive the licence.

Part 8. Two-wheeler or car: what the test differs on

The class you choose changes the vehicle, the ground test and a few rules. Here is the side-by-side.

	Two-wheeler (MCWOG / MCWG)	Car (LMV)
Vehicle for the test	A two-wheeler of the class you applied for.	A car; many candidates use a driving-school vehicle.
Ground test	Balance and control, including a figure-of-eight.	Reverse-parallel parking, a controlled stop, three-point turn.
Safety gear	A helmet is compulsory for rider and pillion.	Seat belts for driver and passengers.
Pillion / passengers	No pillion other than an instructor on a learner's licence.	Only those allowed by the licence and the vehicle.
What examiners watch	Balance, braking, road sense.	Mirrors, clutch control, lane discipline, judgement.

Both tests end with the same thing: a drive on a public road, observed. The habits that pass one pass the other — mirror checks, clear signalling, and driving at a pace that matches the road.

Part 9. The complete fee sheet

These are the national fees for licensing services under Rule 32 of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989. States may add a smart-card charge and small user charges, so treat this as the base and confirm the total on your state's SARATHI page.

Service	Fee (national base)
Issue of learner's licence, per class of vehicle (Form 3)	Rs. 150
Learner's licence test, or repeat test	Rs. 50
Test of competence to drive, per class (the driving test)	Rs. 300
Issue of a driving licence	Rs. 200
International Driving Permit (IDP)	Rs. 1,000
Addition of another class of vehicle to a licence	Rs. 500
Endorsement or renewal for hazardous-goods vehicles	Rs. 1,000
Renewal of a driving licence	Rs. 200
Renewal applied for after the grace period	Rs. 300, plus Rs. 1,000 for each year (or part) of delay

Two extras to budget for: a smart-card charge (commonly around Rs. 200) for the physical card, and any state user charge. The learner's-licence fee, the learner's-test fee and the driving-test fee are usually collected together at the time of the learner's application.

9.1 Vehicle-side fees you may need

Service	Fee (national base)
Registration of a new motorcycle	Rs. 300
Registration of a light motor vehicle (non-transport)	Rs. 600
Smart-card RC (Form 23A)	Rs. 200 additional
Certificate of fitness, transport vehicle	Rs. 200
Renewal of registration, vehicle older than 20 years	Motorcycle Rs. 2,000; LMV Rs. 10,000

Part 10. Document checklists

Missing a single document is the fastest way to lose a day at the RTO. Keep these lists on your phone.

10.1 For a new learner's licence

- Form 2 — the application (filled online).
- Form 1 — self-declaration of physical fitness.
- Proof of age and address — Aadhaar, passport, voter ID, school or birth certificate, or a government pay slip.
- A recent passport-size photograph and your signature, in the size the portal specifies.
- A parent's or guardian's declaration, if you are under 18.

10.2 For the permanent driving licence

- Original learner's licence.
- Form 1 (and Form 1A if applying for a transport licence, or if you are above 40).
- Appointment or acknowledgement slip and the fee receipt.
- A recent passport-size photograph.
- A vehicle of the correct class, with valid registration, insurance and PUC.

10.3 Accepted proof of age and address

Form 2 lists the documents an RTO will accept as proof of both age and address. Pick the one that covers both and carry the original plus a photocopy:

Accepted proofs	
Aadhaar card	Electoral roll / voter ID
Passport	School certificate

Accepted proofs	
Birth certificate	Life insurance policy
Government pay slip	Affidavit sworn before a magistrate or notary
Medical practitioner's age certificate	Any other proof the state government specifies

A passport is the easiest single document — it proves both age and address. If you cannot produce any listed proof for a good reason, the licensing authority may accept an affidavit sworn before an Executive Magistrate, a First Class Judicial Magistrate or a Notary Public.

Part 11. Validity and renewal — never let it lapse

An expired licence is not a small matter: it is the difference between a warning and a Rs. 5,000 challan for driving without a valid licence. Know your validity date and renew ahead of it.

11.1 How long your licence is valid

Licence type	Validity
Learner's licence	6 months from issue.
Non-transport (private) — issued under age 30	Until you turn 40.
Non-transport — issued between 30 and 50	10 years from issue or renewal.
Non-transport — issued between 50 and 55	Until you turn 60.
Non-transport — issued at 55 or above	5 years from issue or renewal.
Transport vehicle	5 years from issue or renewal.
Transport — hazardous goods	3 years.

11.2 How to renew

1. Apply on SARATHI under 'Services on Driving Licence' → Renewal, ideally within the month before your licence expires.
2. Upload Form 1 (self-declaration). Form 1A (medical certificate) is required for transport licences and for anyone above 40.
3. Pay the renewal fee (Rs. 200), plus the smart-card charge.
4. Take an appointment and visit the RTO with the originals, or complete it online where your state supports it.

11.3 If you renew late

- A 30-day grace period applies after expiry, within which the renewal is treated as continuous from the expiry date.
- Beyond 30 days, the licence is renewed with effect from the date of the application, and a higher fee applies — Rs. 300 plus Rs. 1,000 for each year (or part of a year) of delay.
- If more than one year has passed, many states require a fresh driving test; if more than five years have passed, you must go through the full process to obtain a fresh licence.

Part 12. Every other licence service you may need

Your licence is not just for driving — it is a record that needs updating through life. All of these are handled on SARATHI under the driving-licence menu.

Service	When you need it	Notes
Duplicate licence	Lost, stolen, damaged or defaced.	A copy of the police complaint is required if lost or stolen.
Change of address	You have moved.	Form 2; carry proof of the new address.
Change of name	Marriage, or a legal name change.	Affidavit, marriage certificate or a newspaper advertisement, as the RTO asks.
Addition of a class	You want to drive a new type of vehicle.	Form 2 and Form 1; a fresh test for the new class.
International Driving Permit	Driving abroad.	Passport and visa proof required; Rs. 1,000.
DL extract	A certified copy for visa or insurance use.	State-specific; apply at the RTO.
Surrender of a class	You no longer want to drive a class.	Form 8; the class is removed from your licence.
PSV badge	Driving a public service vehicle commercially.	Validity and rules follow state policy.

Part 13. Your digital documents

You do not need to carry a plastic card to prove you have a licence. Digital copies are accepted, and in some states they are now the primary document.

13.1 Where to find them

- **DigiLocker** — the government document wallet. A driving licence or RC pulled up here is a valid, legally recognised copy.
- **mParivahan** — the MoRTH app that shows your DL and RC, and lets you verify a vehicle's details.
- **SARATHI and VAHAN** — the portals behind them: SARATHI for licence services, VAHAN for vehicle services.

13.2 The move to digital issuance

Tamil Nadu switched its driving licences and registration certificates to digital issuance from 15 September 2026, downloadable through SARATHI, VAHAN, DigiLocker and mParivahan. The state also urged holders to keep their mobile number updated on the DL and RC so that online services work without an RTO visit. Expect more states to follow.

Update your mobile number now

Most digital services — slot booking, renewal, OTP verification — are tied to the mobile number registered against your licence and vehicle. If you have changed numbers, update it on SARATHI (for the DL) and VAHAN (for the RC) so you are not locked out when you need a service most.

Part 14. The vehicle side: RC, PUC, insurance, FASTag, fitness

Your licence lets you drive; your vehicle's papers let you drive legally. These are the documents that must be valid every time the vehicle is on the road.

14.1 The RC (registration certificate)

The RC is proof that the vehicle is registered in your name. Keep the details — registration number, chassis and engine number, owner name — matching reality. Change of address, hypothecation, duplicate RC and transfer of ownership are all VAHAN services.

14.2 The PUC certificate — and the 2026 crackdown

A Pollution Under Control certificate shows your vehicle's emissions are within limits. Under Rule 115(7) of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, every fuel-based vehicle must carry a valid PUC from one year after its first registration, and produce it on demand. It costs roughly Rs. 50 to Rs. 150 depending on the vehicle. Electric vehicles are exempt, because they have no tailpipe emissions.

The penalty for driving without a valid PUC is now severe. Under Section 190(2) of the Motor Vehicles Act, a first offence can attract a penalty of up to Rs. 10,000 and a three-month disqualification from holding a licence; a repeat offence can mean up to six months' imprisonment, a fine of up to Rs. 10,000, or both. Delhi compounds the offence at the Rs. 10,000 ceiling.

From 1 October 2026, Delhi began a 'no PUC, no fuel' enforcement drive: petrol pumps with number-plate recognition refuse fuel to vehicles without a valid PUC. Registered vehicles from outside Delhi that do not meet BS-VI standards are to be barred from entering the city from 1 November 2026. Other states have taken their own line — Odisha cut its PUC fines sharply in September 2026 after a public backlash, to Rs. 1,000 for a two- or three-wheeler and Rs. 2,000 for a car on a first offence.

Renewal rhythm for your PUC

BS-IV and BS-VI vehicles renew the PUC annually; vehicles below BS-IV renew every six months. Put a reminder in your calendar one month before each expiry — it costs a few rupees to renew and up to Rs. 10,000 not to.

14.3 Insurance

Third-party motor insurance is mandatory. Driving without valid insurance attracts a fine of about Rs. 2,000. A lapsed policy is one of the quietest ways to get caught — the RC and insurance details are linked in VAHAN, so an enforcement camera can flag a lapsed policy as easily as a red-light jump. Beyond the compulsory third-party cover, a comprehensive policy adds protection for your own vehicle, and a No Claim Bonus (NCB) rewards a claim-free year with a discount on the next premium.

14.4 FASTag

FASTag is the electronic toll-payment tag on your windscreen. Since January 2026, unpaid National Highway user fees are tied to RTO services: a No Objection Certificate for transferring a vehicle, or a certificate of fitness, will not be issued until any unpaid toll dues are cleared. Keep the FASTag funded and the vehicle's details current.

14.5 Fitness certificate

Transport (commercial) vehicles need a certificate of fitness, renewed at prescribed intervals. The 2026 rules tightened this: renewal now requires a geo-tagged video of the vehicle, and a vehicle declared unfit that is not re-certified within 180 days may be categorised as an End of Life Vehicle.

Part 15. Buying or selling a used vehicle: RC transfer and NOC

A used-vehicle deal is not complete until the RC is in the buyer's name. Until then, the seller remains legally responsible for the vehicle — and the buyer cannot insure or resell it cleanly.

15.1 Transfer within the same state

- The seller files **Form 29** (notice of transfer) with the registering authority.
- The buyer applies in **Form 30** within **14 days** of the transfer, with the supporting documents.
- The process is now initiated on VAHAN — the seller starts the transfer, and the buyer completes it.

15.2 Transfer from another state

- The buyer applies within **45 days** of the transfer.
- The vehicle needs a **No Objection Certificate (NOC)** in **Form 28** from the state where it is registered.
- Apply for the NOC on VAHAN under 'Online Services' → NOC, using the registration number and the last five digits of the chassis number.

15.3 Documents you will need

Document	Why
Form 29 (transferor)	Notice that the vehicle has been sold.
Form 30 (transferee)	Application to record the transfer.
Form 28 (if inter-state)	No Objection Certificate from the home state.
Form 34	Consent of the financier, if the vehicle is under hypothecation.
Original RC, valid insurance, valid PUC	Core vehicle documents.
PAN card or Form 60 (buyer and seller)	Tax compliance.
Pencil print of chassis and engine numbers	Identity of the vehicle.
Address proof and photograph of the buyer	To record the new owner.

The hypothecation trap

If the vehicle is still under a car or two-wheeler loan, the financier holds a hypothecation on the RC. You cannot transfer ownership without the financier's consent in Form 34. Clear the loan and get the hypothecation removed first, or line up the NOC from the financier before you agree the sale.

Part 16. Buying a new vehicle: the RTO steps

When you buy new, the dealer handles most of the paperwork — but you should know what is happening, because the registration is in your name.

1. The dealer issues a temporary registration so you can drive home; it is valid for up to about a month.
2. The dealer files the registration application on VAHAN within that window.
3. You receive the permanent registration number, and the RC is issued.
4. A high-security registration plate (HSRP) is fitted — mandatory on new vehicles.
5. Road tax is paid (usually a one-time lifetime tax for private vehicles, set by the state).
6. Insurance and FASTag are arranged; the PUC becomes due one year after first registration.

16.1 The forms behind a new registration

Form	What it is
Form 20	Application for registration of a motor vehicle.
Form 21	Sale certificate issued by the dealer.
Form 22	Certificate of roadworthiness from the manufacturer.
Form 23	The certificate of registration itself.
Invoice, insurance, PAN or Form 60, address proof, road-tax receipt	Supporting documents.

Private vehicles pay a one-time lifetime road tax, which varies by state and by the vehicle's price or engine capacity. Confirm the exact figure with your dealer and on your state transport department's site before you sign.

Part 17. What is changing in your state (verified notes)

Transport is a state subject in practice, and the states are moving at different speeds. Here are the changes verified as of October 2026.

State	What is changing
Kerala	Hazard Perception Test mandatory for driving-licence applicants from 1 December 2026 — the first in India. Four-stage test: learner's test, HPT, ground test, road test.
Delhi	'No PUC, no fuel' enforcement from 1 October 2026, with number-plate recognition at fuel stations. Registered vehicles from outside Delhi that are not BS-VI are to be barred from 1 November 2026.

State	What is changing
Tamil Nadu	Digital driving licences and registration certificates issued through SARATHI, VAHAN, DigiLocker and mParivahan from 15 September 2026. Heavy transport licence holders take a one-day refresher course at approved schools.
Telangana	A mandatory online road-safety awareness test before the learner's licence is proposed, following a Supreme Court SOP on road safety.
Odisha	PUC violation fines cut sharply in September 2026 — Rs. 1,000 for a two- or three-wheeler and Rs. 2,000 for a car on a first offence, instead of the Rs. 10,000 ceiling.

These are the verified, dated changes. Always check your own state transport department's site for the latest, because fees and processes change through the year.

Part 18. Traffic rules and challans in 2026

India's penalties come from the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019, and states set their compounding amounts within those ceilings. Enforcement is now largely automatic, so the numbers below are the ones that land in your inbox as an e-challan.

Offence	Penalty (national ceiling)
Driving without a licence	Rs. 5,000
Driving without valid insurance	Rs. 2,000
Driving without a valid PUC	Up to Rs. 10,000 and a 3-month licence disqualification
Driving without a valid RC	Rs. 5,000
Drunk driving	Rs. 10,000 and/or imprisonment up to 6 months
Riding without a helmet (rider or pillion)	Rs. 1,000 and a 3-month licence disqualification
Not wearing a seat belt (Section 194B)	Rs. 1,000
Using a hand-held mobile phone while driving	Rs. 5,000 (first), Rs. 10,000 (repeat)
Dangerous or rash driving	Rs. 5,000 (first), Rs. 10,000 (repeat)
Triple riding on a two-wheeler	Rs. 1,000 and licence disqualification
Jumping a red light	Rs. 1,000 to Rs. 5,000
Overspeeding	Rs. 1,000 (LMV) to Rs. 2,000 (medium/heavy)
Allowing a minor to drive	Rs. 25,000 and possible imprisonment

18.1 The five-offence suspension

Since January 2026, committing five or more traffic offences within a single year can lead to a three-month suspension of your driving licence. Crucially, the list now includes minor offences — a loose helmet strap, an unfastened seat belt, jumping a red light — not just serious ones. Each year is treated separately, so last year's offences do not carry forward.

18.2 Paying an e-challan

Most challans can be paid online through the state traffic-police portal or the Parivahan e-challan service. Unpaid dues can block RTO services and, in some states, the issue of a fresh PUC. If a challan is wrong, contest it with the issuing authority rather than ignoring it — an unpaid fine only grows.

18.3 Documents to keep valid

Keep these five current and reachable in DigiLocker or mParivahan: driving licence, RC, insurance, PUC certificate, and (for commercial vehicles) the fitness certificate. If you drive in Delhi, add a valid PUC to that list before you reach the fuel pump.

Part 19. The 30-day action plan

Whether you are getting a first licence or cleaning up your vehicle's papers, here is a month-long plan that ends with everything in order.

19.1 Getting your first licence

Day	Action
1	Decide your class (Part 2) and confirm the age you qualify at. Gather Aadhaar and a photograph.
2-3	Fill Form 2 on SARATHI, upload documents, and pay the learner's fee.
4-7	Take the learner's test (online where available) and download Form 3.
8-37	Practise with an 'L' board. Respect the mandatory waiting gap before the driving test.
30-35	Book the driving-test slot on SARATHI.
38-40	Take the ground and road tests. In Kerala, clear the Hazard Perception Test first.
41-45	Collect or download your licence. Save it in DigiLocker.

19.2 Cleaning up your vehicle's papers

Day	Action
1	Check your DL and RC expiry dates on mParivahan. Update your mobile number on both.
2	Renew the PUC if it is within a month of expiry; note the next renewal date.
3	Check the insurance renewal date; set a reminder for a month before.
4	Top up the FASTag and clear any unpaid toll dues.
5	Clear any pending e-challans through the state portal or Parivahan.
6-7	File the papers, save digital copies, and note all future dates in one calendar.

The one-page habit

Keep a single note — on paper or in your phone — with five dates: DL expiry, RC renewal, PUC renewal, insurance renewal and FASTag top-up. Review it on the first of every month. That habit alone prevents nearly every RTO penalty in this guide.

Part 20. The RTO services directory

Every common licence and vehicle service, with the portal it runs on and the form it needs. Licence services are on SARATHI; vehicle services are on VAHAN.

20.1 Driving-licence services (SARATHI)

Service	Form(s)	Fee
New learner's licence	Form 2, Form 1	Rs. 150 per class, plus Rs. 50 test
New driving licence	Form 2, Form 1 (or 1A)	Rs. 200, plus Rs. 300 test
Renewal of a licence	Form 2, Form 1 (or 1A)	Rs. 200
Duplicate licence	Form 2	Rs. 200 plus smart-card charge
Change of address in a licence	Form 2	As notified by the state
Change of name in a licence	Form 2	As notified by the state
Addition of a class	Form 2, Form 1 (or 1A)	Rs. 500, plus Rs. 300 test
International Driving Permit	Form 2, with passport and visa	Rs. 1,000

20.2 Vehicle services (VAHAN)

Service	Form(s)	Fee
New vehicle registration	Form 20, 21, 22	Rs. 300 (motorcycle) / Rs. 600 (LMV), plus Rs. 200 smart card
Transfer of ownership	Form 29, 30	As notified by the state
No Objection Certificate (inter-state)	Form 28	As notified by the state
Change of address in the RC	Form 33	As notified by the state
Duplicate RC	Form 26	As notified by the state
Hypothecation add / remove	Form 34 / Form 35	As notified by the state
Certificate of fitness (transport)	Form 38	Rs. 200

Fees for vehicle services are set by each state within the national framework, so the exact amount shows up on VAHAN when you start the application. The licensing fees above are the Rule 32 national base.

Part 21. Sample applications you can adapt

Some RTO services still want a short covering application. These are models — copy them, fill the blanks, and check your state's wording before you submit.

21.1 Application for a duplicate driving licence

To, The Licensing Authority, [RTO name], [district]. Subject: Application for a duplicate driving licence. Sir/Madam, I hold driving licence number [number], issued at [RTO], valid for class [class], which has been [lost / damaged / defaced]. A copy of the police complaint (where applicable) is enclosed. I request a duplicate licence. Name: [name]. Address: [address]. Date of birth: [DOB]. Enclosures: proof of identity and address, photograph, police complaint. Yours faithfully, [name], [date].

21.2 Application for a No Objection Certificate (Form 28)

To, The Registering Authority, [RTO name], [state]. Subject: Application for a No Objection Certificate. Sir/Madam, I am the registered owner of vehicle [registration number], a [make and model]. I intend to take the vehicle to [new state] and re-register it there. The road tax up to date and the valid insurance and PUC are enclosed. I request a No Objection Certificate in Form 28. Name: [name]. Address: [address]. Yours faithfully, [name], [date].

21.3 Application for a change of address

To, The Licensing Authority, [RTO name], [district]. Subject: Application for a change of address in my driving licence. Sir/Madam, I hold driving licence number [number]. My address has changed from [old address] to [new address]. Proof of the new address is enclosed. I request the address be updated. Name: [name]. Date of birth: [DOB]. Yours faithfully, [name], [date].

Most services now accept these online, where the form is filled on the portal rather than on paper. Use the templates only where your RTO still asks for a written covering application.

Part 22. The one-page quick-reference card

Everything you are most likely to need, on one card. Screenshot it or print it and keep it with your papers.

What	The number to remember
Learner's licence fee	Rs. 150 per class, plus Rs. 50 test fee
Driving test fee	Rs. 300; DL issue Rs. 200
Licence renewal fee	Rs. 200 (Rs. 300 plus Rs. 1,000 per year after the grace period)
Learner's licence validity	6 months
Private licence validity	Until age 40, then 10 years, then 5 years
Transport licence validity	5 years (3 years for hazardous goods)
Waiting gap before the driving test	30 days after the learner's test
Minimum age	16 (MCWOG) · 18 (LMV / MCWG) · 20 (transport)
PUC certificate	Due one year after first registration; costs Rs. 50–150
Fine, no valid PUC	Up to Rs. 10,000 plus a 3-month disqualification
Fine, no licence	Rs. 5,000
Fine, no helmet / no seat belt	Rs. 1,000 each
Fine, phone while driving	Rs. 5,000 (first offence)
Five offences in a year	3-month licence suspension
Renewal grace period	30 days after expiry
Key portals	SARATHI (licence) · VAHAN (vehicle) · DigiLocker / mParivahan (digital)

Part 23. Test-day checklist

The day of the driving test is short and unforgiving. Turn up prepared and the test is mostly done before you start the engine.

20.1 What to carry

- Your original learner's licence.
- The appointment or acknowledgement slip and the fee receipt.
- Form 1 (and Form 1A for a transport test, or if you are above 40).
- A recent passport-size photograph.
- Your Aadhaar or another accepted photo identity, for verification.

20.2 The vehicle

- It must match the class you are being tested for.
- Registration, insurance and PUC must all be valid on the day.
- Fit an 'L' board at the front and rear if you are practising or driving to the test on a learner's licence.
- For a two-wheeler, bring a helmet; for a car, the seat belts must work.

20.3 How the day runs

1. Report at the RTO or test ground at the time on your slip.
2. Complete verification and any on-the-spot formalities.
3. In Kerala from December 2026, take the computer-based Hazard Perception Test first and clear 60 out of 100.
4. Take the ground test, then the road test.
5. If you pass, the licence is processed and dispatched; download or collect it.

If you fail

A failed test is not the end of the road. You pay a repeat test fee (Rs. 300 for the competence test, or Rs. 50 for the learner's test) and book a fresh appointment on SARATHI. Most failures come down to practice hours — more behind-the-wheel time, not more test attempts, is the fix.

Part 24. Licence myths, and what is actually true

A lot of licence advice circulates that was true years ago, or was never true at all. Here are the ten myths that cost people time and money.

The myth	The truth
You cannot get a licence without a driving school.	Schools are optional for private licences. Training is required only for some transport classes.

The myth	The truth
A digital licence is not valid.	A DL shown in DigiLocker or mParivahan is accepted as valid proof.
You can take the driving test right after the learner's test.	No — a mandatory waiting gap (traditionally 30 days) applies.
A two-wheeler licence lets you drive a car.	No. Classes are separate; a car needs the LMV class.
Once you have a licence, you never renew it.	No. A private licence renews in blocks (for example, until 40, then 10 years, then 5).
A new vehicle needs no PUC.	The PUC becomes due one year after the vehicle's first registration.
An expired licence stays valid for years.	There is a 30-day grace period; beyond it, higher fees apply, and a long lapse may need a fresh test.
You can drive on someone else's licence.	No. Driving without a valid licence of your own attracts a Rs. 5,000 fine.
A learner's licence lasts a year.	It is valid for six months from issue.
Electric vehicles need a PUC.	No. EVs are exempt from the PUC requirement.

Part 25. Common rejection reasons — and the fix

Applications are returned for a small set of predictable reasons. Here they are, with the fix.

What went wrong	How to fix it
Wrong class of vehicle selected	Match the class on Form 2 to the vehicle you will actually drive.
Name or date of birth mismatch	Make the spelling and DOB identical across Aadhaar, the form and the proof you upload.
Address proof not matching	Use a proof that shows the address exactly as you typed it; update Aadhaar first if needed.
Photo or signature rejected	Use the portal's specified dimensions and a clear, recent photograph.
Missing Form 1 or 1A	Form 1 for private; Form 1A medical for transport or above 40.
Slot booked before the waiting period	Respect the mandatory gap from the learner's test before the driving test.
Vehicle papers expired at the test	Ensure the vehicle's insurance and PUC are valid on test day.
Fee paid but slot not confirmed	Recheck the appointment status on SARATHI; rebook if the slot lapsed.

Part 26. Questions people actually ask

Can I get a learner's licence without going to the RTO?

In many states, yes. The MoRTH service allows a fully faceless learner's licence: apply online, take an AI-proctored test with Aadhaar-based face authentication, and download the licence. Some states still require a visit with originals.

How soon can I take the driving test after the learner's licence?

A mandatory waiting gap applies — traditionally 30 days — between passing the learner's test and the driving test. In Kerala's new process, the Hazard Perception Test must be cleared within 30 days of the learner's test.

How long is my driving licence valid?

A private licence is generally valid for 20 years from issue or until you turn 40, whichever is earlier; it then renews in 10-year, then 5-year blocks. A transport licence is valid for 5 years (3 for hazardous goods).

I lost my licence. What do I do?

Apply for a duplicate on SARATHI. If it was lost or stolen, a copy of the police complaint is required. The duplicate has the same validity as the original.

What is the Hazard Perception Test?

A computer-based test introduced first in Kerala from December 2026. You watch 10 one-minute videos, each with up to two hazards, and click when you spot a danger. You need 60 out of 100 to pass, and it sits between the learner's test and the practical tests.

Is a digital licence valid if a police officer asks?

Yes. A licence shown in DigiLocker or mParivahan is accepted as valid proof. Keep the app updated and your mobile number current.

Do I need a PUC for an electric vehicle?

No. Electric vehicles are exempt from the PUC requirement because they have no tailpipe emissions. Petrol, diesel and CNG vehicles need a valid PUC.

How much is the fine for driving without a licence?

About Rs. 5,000 under the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019. Driving without a valid PUC can attract up to Rs. 10,000 and a three-month disqualification.

Can I drive another state's vehicle on my licence?

Yes — a driving licence issued anywhere in India is valid across the country. But if you move a vehicle to another state, you must obtain an NOC (Form 28) and re-register it there.

I am 16. Can I get a licence?

You can apply for MCWOG (a gearless two-wheeler) as a private vehicle at 16, with a parent's or guardian's declaration. A car or geared motorcycle needs you to be 18; a transport licence needs 20.

Part 27. Glossary of RTO terms

The forms and portals use a shorthand that is rarely explained. Here it is, alphabetical.

Term	Meaning
COV	Class of Vehicle — the category your licence covers (MCWG, LMV, and so on).
MCWOG / MCWG	Motor Cycle Without Gear / With Gear.
LMV / LMV-NT	Light Motor Vehicle / Light Motor Vehicle Non-Transport.

Term	Meaning
SARATHI	The national portal for driving-licence services.
VAHAN	The national portal for vehicle-registration services.
RTO	Regional Transport Office — your local licensing and registration authority.
PUCC	Pollution Under Control Certificate.
NOC	No Objection Certificate — needed to move a vehicle to another state (Form 28).
Hypothecation	The financier's claim on a vehicle bought on a loan; noted on the RC.
IDP	International Driving Permit.
PSV badge	Public Service Vehicle badge for commercial passenger drivers.
ELV	End of Life Vehicle — a vehicle past its useful life, with scrappage rules.
e-challan	An electronic traffic-violation notice, issued manually or by camera.
DigiLocker / mParivahan	The app and wallet that hold your valid digital DL and RC.
Form 1 / 1A	Self-declaration of fitness / medical certificate.
Form 2 / 3	Application for a licence / the learner's licence itself.
Form 20 / 21 / 22	Registration application / dealer's sale certificate / roadworthiness certificate.
Form 28 / 29 / 30	NOC / notice of transfer / application to transfer ownership.
Form 34	Financier's consent to transfer a vehicle under hypothecation.

Part 28. Sources and how to verify

Every figure in this guide comes from an official source. Where a rule can vary by state, the source tells you where to confirm it. Keep these bookmarked:

- **Parivahan / SARATHI** (parivahan.gov.in, sarathi.parivahan.gov.in) — licence services, fees, forms, slot booking and application status.
- **VAHAN** (vahan.parivahan.gov.in) — vehicle registration, RC transfer, NOC, hypothecation and duplicate RC.
- **MoRTH** (morth.nic.in) — the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, and all notifications and amendments.
- **Your state transport department** — the exact fees, slots and local rules for your RTO.
- **DigiLocker and mParivahan** — your digital licence and RC.

The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, and the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019, are the laws behind the penalties. The Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, carry the fee schedule (Rule 32), the PUC requirement (Rule 115) and the licence-validity rules. The Hazard Perception Test in Kerala is notified by that state's Motor Vehicles Department; Tamil Nadu's digital issuance is notified by its Transport Commissionerate.

A final word

Transport rules move fast — fees, slots and enforcement all change between state budgets and amendments. This guide reflects the position as of October 2026. Before you pay or travel, spend two minutes on your state's SARATHI page to confirm the exact amount and requirement. It is the cheapest two minutes in this whole process.

This guide is an independent, informational resource. It is not legal advice and is not affiliated with any government department. Rules, fees and timelines are set by MoRTH and the state transport departments, which are the final authority.